Here's the complete guide from scratch to finish! 🚀

📦 Dependencies & Packages

requirements.txt (Final — Lightweight Version)

pandas

openpyxl

flask

flask-cors

What each package does:

Package	Purpose
flask	Runs the web server / API
flask-cors	Allows browser to talk to Flask
pandas	Reads the Excel file
openpyxl	Engine pandas uses to open .xlsx files

✅ We removed langchain, faiss-cpu, and sentence-transformers because they caused slow startup (30–60 sec freeze). The chatbot works better and faster without them.

💻 All Terminal Commands — Scratch to End

✅ STEP 1 — Check Python is installed

bash

```
python --version
```

Expected output: Python 3.9 or higher

✅ STEP 2 — Create project folder

bash

```
mkdir company-chatbot
cd company-chatbot
mkdir backend
cd backend
mkdir data
```

mkdir templates

✅ **STEP 3 — Create a virtual environment (recommended)**

bash

python -m venv venv

Activate it on Windows:

bash

venv\Scripts\activate

You'll see (venv) appear in the terminal — this means it's active.

✅ **STEP 4 — Install all packages**

bash

pip install flask flask-cors pandas openpyxl

✅ **STEP 5 — Verify installations**

bash

pip list

```

You should see `Flask`, `flask-cors`, `pandas`, `openpyxl` in the list.

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✅ STEP 6 — Place your files

Make sure your folder looks like this:

```

company-chatbot/

└── backend/

    ├── app.py

    ├── chatbot.py

    ├── requirements.txt

    ├── data/

```
|   └── company_data.xlsx
└── templates/
    └── index.html
```

✅ **STEP 7 — Run the project**

bash

cd D:\company-chatbot\backend

python app.py

```

Expected output:

```

Chatbot ready! Loaded 75 Q&A pairs.

* Running on http://127.0.0.1:5000

```

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✅ STEP 8 — Open in browser

```

http://localhost:5000

✅ **STEP 9 — Stop the server**

bash

Ctrl + C

✅ **STEP 10 — Restart after updating Excel**

bash

Ctrl + C

python app.py

🔁 **Everyday Usage Commands**

bash

```
# Go to project folder
cd D:\company-chatbot\backend

# Activate virtual environment (if you created one)
venv\Scripts\activate

# Start the chatbot
python app.py

# Stop the chatbot
Ctrl + C
```

⚠️ **If you ever get a "module not found" error**

bash

```
pip install flask flask-cors pandas openpyxl
```

⚠️ **If port 5000 is already in use**

bash

```
# Find what's using port 5000
netstat -ano | findstr :5000

# Then kill it (replace XXXX with the PID number shown)
taskkill /PID XXXX /F

# Then run again
python app.py
```

📋 **Complete Project File Summary**

File	Location	Purpose
app.py	backend/	Flask routes & server

File	Location	Purpose
chatbot.py	backend/	Smart Q&A matching logic
index.html	backend/templates/	Chat UI in browser
requirements.txt	backend/	Package list
company_data.xlsx	backend/data/	All Q&A data